Ravenswood from Bad Habits

By Terrance McNally

BENSON: *(Reading a list of new patients)* I've been given another chance. I'm the luckiest woman alive. He's here. He's at Ravenswood. I've got him where I want him at last! Oh God! Do you know how many years I've waited for this moment? Hugh Gumbs wants to be a new person and I'll be the one helping him to mold his new self.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Let's face it, all of us have our own bad habits.*
ACTRESS: *We may bite our nails or crack our knuckles.*
ACTOR: *(Interruption) Some of us interrupt people often or procrastinate. All these nasty habits are hard to break.*
ACTRESS: *But have no fear! Ravenswood is a special facility that has the answer! With daily injections . . ., all of your bad habits can be resolved. No pain, no work, no suffering. Call it a quick fix, if you will.*
ACTOR: *Ruth Benson, former patient and now a nurse at the facility is the poster child to prove the program works. Once she was an overweight slob with a horrible drinking and smoking habit . . . but now she's committed her life to helping others . . . and today is her lucky day.*
ACTRESS: *The love of her life, Hugh Gumbs, has checked himself into*
TOGETHER: *Ravenswood from Bad Habits by Terrance McNally.*

Benson wheels in Hugh Gumbs, still wearing his bedraggled street clothes.)

HUGH: Aaaaaaaaaaaaaaaa!

BENSON: Mr. Gumbs, please! You must try to control yourself.

HUGH: Aaaaaaaaaaa!

BENSON: It's obvious you're in great distress, Mr. Gumbs, but surely ...

HUGH: I'm desperate, Nurse. You name it and I've got it, done it or used it.

BENSON: As soon as I've gone over your forms ...

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HUGH: Couldn't I just have my injection first?

BENSON: *(Keeping her head down, looking at her charts.)* Smoking. Three packs a day. That's a lot, Mr. Gumbs.

HUGH: I'm not even being honest with you. It's closer to five.

BENSON: Five packs?

HUGH: Six, seven, I don't know! Some nights I set my alarm and wake up at fifteen-minute intervals and have a cigarette.

BENSON: Why?

HUGH: Why? Because that's how much I like to smoke! What kind of a question is that? Why? Why do people do anything? Because they like it! They like it!

BENSON: Even when it's bad for them?

HUGH: Yes! That's exactly why I'm here! I'm a liar. I'm a kleptomaniac. I chase women. I bite my nails. You've got to help me!

BENSON: Thank God, Hugh, thank God!

HUGH: What?

BENSON: *(Back to the forms.)* A terrible drinking problem. How much exactly?

HUGH: Bloody Marys at breakfast, martinis before lunch ...

BENSON: How many?

HUGH: Two, and three before dinner. And three or four cherry herrings after dinner and hot saki nightcaps.

BENSON: It sounds like you still have your drinking problem all right.

HUGH: Still?

BENSON: *(Aside.)* Oh, Hugh, Hugh, you're breaking my heart!

HUGH: Aaaaaaaaaaaa!

BENSON: I want to help you, Mr. Gumbs!

HUGH: Then do it! Can't we do all this after the injection?

BENSON: I'm afraid not, Hugh. Excuse me, I meant Mr. Gumbs.

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HUGH: That's the first thing I'd like to change about me. My name. How could any woman love a Hugh Gumbs? I meet a woman and it's fine about the drinking, fine about the smoking... but when I tell her my name, it's all over. Ask yourself, nurse, would you want to go through life as Mrs. Hugh Gumbs?

BENSON: Surely there was one woman, somewhere in your life, who didn't mind your name?

HUGH: One, just one.

BENSON: You see?

HUGH: My mother, for Christ's sake! Please, can't I have my first injection?

BENSON: We're nearly done. What really brings you to Ravenswood?

HUGH: I've told you.

BENSON: I thought perhaps there might be a somewhat more personal reason. I only meant perhaps someone else is responsible for your coming here.

HUGH: Like who?

BENSON: A woman.

HUGH: You're telling me! Say, and you're going to think I'm crazy, did you ever work for an answering service? Your voice sounds so familiar.

BENSON: I know.

HUGH: There was this real battle-axe on my service about five years ago. For a minute, you sounded just like her. Where was I?

BENSON: A woman.

HUGH: Oh yeah, a woman. Yes, there is one.

BENSON: Tell me about her.

HUGH: *(With a sigh.)* She was very beautiful, very feminine, very desirable. Everything a man could want. Intelligent, decisive, yet strangely yielding.

BENSON: *(Almost a murmur.)* Yet strangely yielding!

HUGH: She's probably the finest woman alive on the face of this earth.

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BENSON: Her name, Mr. Gumbs?

HUGH: Char-Burger! Did you ever work part-time in Char-Burger on East 63rd Street!

BENSON: I'm afraid not.

HUGH: You sound so familiar and I never forget a voice. Eleven o'clock news weather girl, maybe?

BENSON: No. Her name, Mr. Gumbs?

HUGH: *(A tormented memory.)* Mildred Canby!

BENSON: What about Ruth Benson?

HUGH: Ruth Benson?

BENSON: I believe that's the name on your biography here.

HUGH: I don't remember telling anyone anything about Ruth Benson.

BENSON: You were delirious when they brought you in. You were raving about a Ruth Benson. That's all you said. Ruth Benson, Ruth Benson. Over and over again. She must have been very important to you.

HUGH: Not particularly.

BENSON: I'll be the judge of that. Tell me about her.

HUGH: The main thing I could tell you about Ruth Benson is that she was fat. About 280, I'd say. I mean she was circus fat.

BENSON: I know the type. Go on, Mr. Gumbs.

HUGH: What else about her? I think Ruth Benson is the only person, man, woman or child, I ever asked to take a bath. She used to smoke six packs a day, minimum. Cigarillos. Nicotine stains right up to her elbow! I don't guess she ever drew a sober breath. My main image of her is passed out on the floor like a big rancid mountain. And talk about being a slob! She had dustballs under her bed the size of watermelons. She didn't just have roaches in her kitchen. She raised them. It was like a goddamn stud farm in there. You'd light the oven and there'd be a flash-fire from all the grease.

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BENSON: It sounds like Ruth Benson was a woman with a lot of bad habits.

HUGH: She was an out and out pig.

BENSON: I can't help noticing a special glow that comes into your voice every time you mention her name.

HUGH: We had a lot in common, Ruthie and I. I'll never forget the night we each caught the other precisely the same instant picking their nose. God, she was gross.

BENSON: There's that glow again.

HUGH: Just thinking of her with all those fingers up there and I have to smile. You're bringing back a lot of bad memories, Nurse. I haven't thought of Ruth Benson and her soiled sheets in a long time. Your voice sounds so familiar. *(Benson is making a big show of raising her skirt to fix a stocking.)* You have beautiful legs, Nurse.

BENSON: Familiar voice, unfamiliar legs.

HUGH: The legs look like some movie star, the voice still sounds like that answering voice.

BENSON: *(Straightening up.)* Don't you know who I am yet, Hugh? No, don't say anything until I've finished. I'm not going to turn around until you tell me that you want me to turn around. I'm glad you don't recognize me. There's no reason that you should. I did it all for you, Hugh. Hugh Gumbs. Like your name, it wasn't easy. But I didn't mind the suffering, the self-humiliation, the incredible self-discipline. I wanted to torture myself into becoming someone a man like you could love and I have. Let me finish! I'm brutally honest with myself. That's not enough, I know, hut it's a beginning. When I look in a mirror now I can say yes, yes, I like that person. I'm not smug, Hugh, I just know my own worth. For five years I've made myself thoroughly miserable so that today I could make you happy and I did it all for Jove. *(A pause.)* Now yes or no, Hugh, do

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you want me to turn around? *(A pause.)*

HUGH: Who are you?

BENSON: *(Turning to him, ecstatic.)* It's me. Ruth.

HUGH: Ruth?

BENSON: Ruth Benson.

HUGH: Fat Ruth Benson?

BENSON: Yes, yes!

HUGH: You don't look like Ruth.

BENSON: *(She is so happy.)* I know, I know!

HUGH: You don't sound like her, either.

BENSON: Voice lessons, darling.

HUGH: You don't even smell like Ruth.

BENSON: Zest, Dial, Dove, Lava!

HUGH: You have such beautiful legs,

BENSON: I worked for them.

HUGH: Your teeth.

BENSON: All caps.

HUGH: And your ... *(He indicates her breasts.)*

BENSON: Exercises.

HUGH: Your big hairy mole.

BENSON: Cosmetic surgery.

HUGH: It's really you?

BENSON: It's really me. The real me and it's all for you, Hugh, I did it all for you.

HUGH: You did?

BENSON: And now that I've found you again I'm not going to let you go this time.

HUGH: You didn't let me go the last time. I let you go.

BENSON: It doesn't matter. The point is you won't want to let me go this time. Oh

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Hugh, I'm going to make you very, very happy. You're the luckiest man alive.

HUGH: *(Shaking his head.)* No, Ruth, no. It would never work, Ruth.

BENSON: Of course it will work. It has to work.

HUGH: I couldn't do it to you. Ruth, I've committed myself to Ravenswood, I've gotten so bad.

BENSON: Do you love me?

HUGH: Love you? You're so far above me now. I didn't love you when you were fat and rotten. I can't love you now that you're beautiful and perfect and have such terrific legs.

BENSON: I'm not perfect. I still have my faults, too, darling

HUGH: Like what? Name one.

BENSON: I can't off the top of my head but I'm sure I do somewhere.

HUGH: You see, it's hopeless. You're the sky above and I'm the mud below. Maybe someday I'll be worthy of you but right now I want to forget all about you and try to improve myself, too, and maybe, just maybe, you'll still be up there in the stratosphere, all shiny like an angel, when I poke my head up through the clouds.

BENSON: That was poetic, Hugh.

HUGH: You're an angel. I can't even ask you for a cigarette.

BENSON: Yes. Yes you can. Take the whole pack. I'll light it for you. You want a drink, darling, I'll get you a drink! Go ahead, bite your nails. Do anything you want. I love you. *(She puts her fingers in her nose.)* It can be just like old times together!

HUGH: *{Horrified expression – then slowly puts one finger up his nose)*

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